5.13.4 Family: Euphorbiaceae (Castor Family / Spurge Family)

(In APG classification Peraceae, Phyllanthaceae and Picrodendraceae are excluded from the family Euphorbiaceae)

Systematic position

APG Classification		Bentham and Hooker Classification	
Kingdom	Plantae	Kingdom	Plantae
Clade:	Angiosperms	Class:	Dicotyledonae
Clade:	Eudicots	Sub-class:	Monochlamydeae
Clade:	Rosids	Series:	Unisexuales
Order:	Malpighiales	Order:	Euphorbiales
Family:	Euphorbiaceae	Family:	Euphorbiaceae



Diagnostic features

- Latex is present either milky or watery.
- Inflorescence generally cymose, catkin in *Acalypha*, cyathium in *Euphorbia* sp.
- Flowers apetalous, unisexual.
- Ovary tricarpellary, distinctly trilobed.
- Fruit capsule or regma.

General characters

Distribution: Euphorbiaceae includes 214 genera and about 5600 species. The plants of this family are found throughout the world. Well represented in Africa and South America.

Habit: Mostly shrubs (*Ricinus communics, Jatropha gossypifolia*) or tree *Emblica officinalis*, herbs (*Phyllanthus amarus*) , twiners (*Tragia involucrata*) some are xerophytic (*Euphorbia*) with cactus – like (phylloclades) plants usually contain milky or watery sap.

Root: Well branched tap root system.

Stem: Aerial, erect or prostrate (*E.prostrata*), herbaceous or woody. Stem becomes modified into flattened, leaf-like and becomes succulent in several species of *Euphorbia*. Such modified stem is called phylloclades. Cylindrical, branched, solid or hollow, usually contain latex either milky (*E.tirucalli*) or watery (*Jatropha curcas*).

Leaf: Stipulate or exstipulate. Mostly simple, alternate, often reduced or deciduous as in several species of *Euphorbia*, palmately lobed in *Ricinus* or deeply lobed in *Manihot*. The stiplues are modified into a pair of spines (*E.splendens*) or glandular hairs (*Jatropha curcas*). The leaves around the cyathium inflorescence become beautifully coloured in *E.pulcherrima* (Paalperukki tree) with unicostate or multicostate reticulate